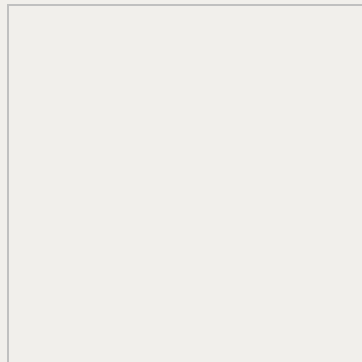


IN CONTEXT

The Unknowns and the Like-Minded

Giulio Strozzi (1583–1652), Barbara Strozzi's father, was a member of the *Accademia degli Incogniti* (Academy of the Unknowns), a circle of prominent Venetian intellectuals who were highly influential in political and cultural life in the region and did much to promote opera in Venice. In 1637, Giulio founded the *Accademia degli Unisoni* (the Academy of the Like-Minded), a musical offshoot of the Unknowns, where he showcased his daughter's vocal and musical talent. Barbara was the academy's dazzling hostess and would often sing and perform her own compositions. Women were seldom permitted into such gatherings—her presence there sparked scandal and satirical commentary, and contributed to her reputation not only as a notable, and beautiful, composer-performer, but also as a courtesan.



GIULIO STROZZI,
BARBARA'S FATHER, c.
1620s

Born in Venice around 1619, Barbara Strozzi was the illegitimate